United States is seeking to enlist India to contain China's rise. Significantly, in his Shangri-La Dialogue speech, Prime Minister Modi did not talk about the Quadrilateral Dialogue between India, the United States, Japan, and Australia (the Quad), even when he mentioned Japanese and American participation in the Malabar Exercise.[57] It may be recalled that Australia had decided to keep away from Malabar 2017 either at the American or Chinese behest, and consequently India did not invite Australia for Malabar 2018.[58] Unlike Japan, Australia, and the United States, India is not party to military alliances directed against third countries and is consequently careful about sending the right signals to China. The Malabar Naval Exercise was originally begun in 1992 as a bilateral exercise between India and the United States, before Japan became a permanent partner to the exercise in 2015. Australia and Singapore have also taken part in it. In 2007, the exercise was for the first time conducted outside the Indian Ocean, off the Japanese island of Okinawa, while the 2018 exercise took place off Guam in the Philippine Sea. The 2019 Malabar again took place in the Pacific Ocean close to Japan, with two Indian Navy vessels partaking.[59]

India is aware of misgivings in China about the future direction of India's policy resulting from closer ties between India and the United States. Indo–US initiatives, like joint statements; the re-energising of the strategic partnership through stronger defence, security, and economic cooperation, including by expanding the Malabar naval exercise; and upgrading trilateral consultations between India, Japan, and the United States to the foreign ministers level are all being met with suspicion in Beijing. China considers the Quad to be directed against itself and as a kind of precursor to an Asian NATO,[60] while Quad members view it more as a consultation mechanism in the region, given the military and political challenges set in motion because of a robust projection of China's comprehensive national power.